

830,000 m² of green land built over?

A newsroom's satellite estimate, tested against its own map, high-resolution images and a land-cover model

THE CLAIM

“Nearly 830,000 square metres of nature and cropland have been built up in Malta between 2018 and 2023.”

Amphora Media, Green to Grey, 11 September 2026

The press is held to the same standard as everyone else.

Companion piece: “nearly 95%” of it was farmland.

VERDICT

NOT SUBSTANTIATED

*Built over by 2025, not 2023;
a third was not farmland.*

SUPPORTED

LARGELY
SUPPORTED

NOT
SUBSTANTIATED

MISLEADING

CONTRADICTED

MAIN RESULTS

0.83 km²

Amphora's map adds up

Its 397 published polygons cover 828,429 m²: “nearly 830,000” is exact.

72.5%

Imagery confirms most

of a random sample of that area went from green to grey (2015–16 to 2025 images).

59%

Fields, not 95%

of the sampled land was fields before; 64% with orchards. The rest: scrub, garrigue.

55%

By 2023, not 830,000

of Amphora's area was grey by May 2023: about 456,000 m². The rest followed by 2025.

93.7 ha

EEA figures check out

New artificial land 2012–2018 in the EEA's change maps; Amphora quotes 92 ha.

FAIR TO SAY

Amphora published its map, so anyone can check it, and most of the land in it really was built over. Our imagery check is by eye on 40 draws, and fallow fields can look like scrub.

WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT

☐ Basis of the 95% figure.

☐ Imagery year: 2023 or 2025?

☐ Class of the unknown 37%.

☐ Development-zone status.